

Rosh Chodesh

In honor of ראש חודש, I'd like to bring a vort which is a מעשה that happened to me, from Hallel, from a very famous pasuk סבויני גם סבויני בשם ה' כי אמילם, in the קאפיטל of המצר.

When I was in high school, we had a דקדוק teacher, and as most ישיבה kids, we all really didn't care much for דקדוק. We took it because we had no ברירה, and we suffered through it. The Rabbi of our particular class was Rabbi Rapps, happened to be a very טייערער מענטש, a very sweet man, so we gave him the כבוד of not giving him too much grief.

One of the very few things that I remember from those years was this pasuk, where he taught us the principle of כפולים. כפולים are Hebrew verbs with two similar letters, and if there are two similar letters, there are different ways to conjugate that verb. He used the word לסבוב as an example, to turn or to surround. And he brought this pasuk. He said you can say סבויני, or you can also say סבויני. The פסוק employs both of these terms: סבויני גם סבויני.

Fast forward four years, I'm in Yeshiva University in Yeshiva College, where we had to do דקדוק all over again. This particular מורה was not very well liked; he was a very strict grammarian, and we all could not stand grammar and דקדוק. When he came to the lesson on כפולים, he said you have to do כפולים with only one letter. He only used one example, I don't remember what it was.

I raised my hand and I said, "How about in Hallel, סבויני גם סבויני?" He said, "That's תנ"ך, people don't talk that way anymore." "But it's there in a pasuk!" I protested in vain. He didn't really much care, but I did put in my מחאה, I did put in my protest, and he didn't win; I felt that I won.

After that class I went back to my high school notes from four years previously (which I kept very meticulously in those days), whipped out my notes from that class of סבויני גם סבויני, trekked my way back to the high school which was a block and a half away from the college building, found Rabbi Rapps in his class, knocked on the door, went in, and said, "Rabbi Rapps, can I bother you for one second?"

I said, "You taught us a principle about כפולים and I remembered it, and we had it now in class and I questioned the מורה because I said you can do it סבויני גם סבויני."

He was astounded! His face broke into the widest grin, he grabbed my notes, showed it to the class, and he said, "Look, look, he kept his notes from my class!" He was so proud of me for having remembered something that he taught me years earlier.

I've met him many times over the years. I met him many times at שמהות, and even up here in the verdant Catskills where he had a place nearby, and each time we met, we didn't say שלום עליכם, we both said simultaneously, "סבויני גם סבויני."

It was such a pleasure to be מהנה another Yid, which is a good message, something we should all learn from. One of the most important things we can do in our life, if not the most important, is to be מהנה other Yidden. When you're מהנה another Yid, you're doing רצון השם, רצון פמוך, ואהבת לרעהך כמוך, and you're doing a tremendous מצוה.